

1 Introduction

lobal corporations now operate at a scale that eclipses most nation-states. For Marx, this reflects capitalism's inherent drive to expand, seeking world markets and centralising capital. Lenin radicalised this as *imperialism*: the monopoly stage of capitalism, powered by finance and the export of capital under uneven development. If accumulation is planetary, governance must match its scale.

My previous conceptual and normative analyses examined, through a Marxist lens, how globalisation reshapes political authority and embeds class power across borders. Marx and Engels described a bourgeoisie dissolving all local barriers to profit.¹ Wolf later reframed this as a totalising incorporation of societies into capitalism's circuits of accumulation.² Lenin adds that, in the imperialist stage, capitalism forms a world system of monopolies and finance capital, characterised by concentration, integration, and expansion beyond national boundaries.³

This paper asks whether supranational governance can restrain global capital while avoiding Miliband's diagnosis of the state as structurally *non-neutral*.

2 Contemporary Imperialism

If imperialism condenses monopoly, finance, and uneven development, contemporary multinationals instantiate these logics.⁴ *Natural resource multinationals* (e.g., Shell) secure rents through global extraction and contractual regimes whose ecological and social externalities concentrate in the periphery while profits flow to metropolitan centres. *Cultural-brand multinationals* (e.g., Heineken) commodify identity and conviviality through global marketing and distribution, displacing local producers and embedding a homogenised consumer aesthetic, exporting lifestyle and belonging as marketable culture. *Digital platform multinationals* (e.g., Google or Apple) govern communications infrastructures, extracting data rents through proprietary ecosystems and intellectual property control. This constitutes not merely economic power but *epistemic rule*: the capacity to define access, visibility, and interaction itself.

[!] [page\(s\)](#) link to source when given.

[!] [] denote own interpretive synthesis; [" "] paraphrase; [' '] quote.

¹ Marx and Engels (1888), [p. 16](#): ['It must nestle everywhere, settle everywhere, establish connexions everywhere'].

² Wolf (1982), [p. 1](#): ['The world of humankind constitutes a manifold'].

³ Lenin (1916), [pp. 66–67](#): [Five basic features of imperialism].

⁴ Ibid., [pp. 66–75](#): [A clear description of these logics].

Together, these (limited) examples express both Lenin's imperialism and Wolf's incorporation: material extraction, cultural standardisation, and digital enclosure converge into a planetary regime of accumulation.

3 Recap First Essay

Conceptually, *supranational governance* presupposes three structural premises:

1. Capital's globalising drive;
2. The state's structural articulation with capital; and
3. The proletariat's international horizon.

These entail necessity and risk: scaling authority to match accumulation, yet risking reproduction of capitalist logics at higher levels. Wolf's insight of a world with "no outside" makes global coordination historically intelligible, yet leaves open whether such coordination can ever be rendered *emancipatory*.

Normatively, arguments *for* supranational governance stress disciplining multinationals, setting transnational labour and environmental standards, and enabling redistribution beyond tax arbitrage. Arguments *against* highlight elite capture, core–periphery reproduction, technocratic insulation, and democratic distance. The verdict: only forms embedding material counter-power and constraining capital's mobility retain legitimacy from a Marxist standpoint.

4 Miliband's Intervention

Miliband's central claim is that the state in capitalist society is not an impartial broker but *structurally biased* toward dominant economic interests.⁵ Administrative and judicial elites are far from *neutral*; they function as elements of cohesion within the class structure of advanced capitalism, reproducing conservative orientations that stabilise accumulation rather than subvert it. For Miliband, the celebrated ideal of civil service 'neutrality' is a *fiction*: senior officials, drawn from similar social backgrounds, shape policy through entrenched ideological dispositions and thereby act as a brake on transformation.⁶ Even state *intervention*, he argues, tends to aid capitalist enterprise by sustaining the interest of property and profitability rather than challenging them.⁷ Politically, governments in advanced capitalism have not been neutral vis-à-vis socialist competition, and frequently deploy the state's coercive and communicative capacities to contain labour militancy.⁸

⁵ Miliband (1969), [pp. 265–266](#): ["State as 'guardian and protector' of dominant interests"].

⁶ Ibid., [pp. 68–83](#): ["Ideological alignment administrative elites"]; Ibid., [pp. 138–145](#): ["Judicial elites and conservative orientation"]; Ibid., [pp. 119–123](#): ["Civil service 'neutrality' rejected"].

⁷ Ibid., [pp. 77–79](#): ["Intervention aids capitalist enterprise"].

⁸ Ibid., [pp. 81–83](#): [governments are not neutral towards the Left].

This implies that if the national state is structurally *non-neutral*, extending its functions to the supranational level risks scaling its bias. Supranational agencies staffed by analogous elites, intertwined with corporate and financial actors, may consolidate capitalist prerogatives under the guise of a *global public interest*. A Milibandian lens thus reverses the default presumption: the burden of proof rests with supranational designs to show not only regulatory capacity but genuine *autonomy* from the class fractions that orient governance toward capital's needs.

5 From Concept to Institution

Integrating the conceptual and normative axes with Miliband yields a set of design conditions delineating the minimum architecture through which supranational governance might attain Marxist credibility:

- ✓ **Material counter-power:** Formal stakeholder language is insufficient; institutions must embed enforceable rights of worker representation and veto over core economic policies (competition, mergers, intellectual property, data governance, climate). Without binding labour power, participation risks theatricality and reproduces the illusion of inclusion.
- ✓ **Jurisdiction over capital mobility:** To defeat regulatory arbitrage, authorities must coordinate on capital controls, minimum effective taxation, union rights portability, and transnational collective bargaining recognition. Without such instruments, supranationalism becomes a conveyor belt for accumulation; harmonising exploitation rather than restraining it.
- ✓ **Democratic control of technocracy:** Executive bodies (commissioners, regulators, central bankers) require direct democratic accountability to transnational constituencies of labour and communities, not merely to member states. Transparency, recall mechanisms, and public oversight are indispensable to prevent elite drift and to convert *expertise* from domination into service.
- ✓ **Core-periphery rebalancing:** Resource transfers in technology, finance, and climate adaptation must be rule-bound, predictable, and enforceable. They should prevent the export of environmental and social costs to the periphery. Standard-setting must be co-determined by peripheral actors, not retrofitted to Northern competitiveness or profitability thresholds.
- ✓ **Platform and IP deconcentration:** Break-up powers and public options for infrastructural platforms (search, social, app distribution, payments, clouds) are prerequisites. Otherwise, supranational regulation merely harmonises monopoly and turns *integration* into a euphemism for corporate centralisation.

These conditions are not auxiliary but constitutive: they define the *only* path through which supranational governance might transform *scale* itself—from an amplifier of

domination into an architecture of counter-hegemonic order. The challenge is not to enlarge the state but to invert its function—turning supranationalism from a mechanism of accumulation into an instrument of collective emancipation.

6 Two Models, Two Trajectories

(A) Regulation-as-harmonisation: This trajectory aligns standards without altering ownership or control. Competition policy trims excesses; tax coordination sets floors; green rules “steer” investment. Through a Milibandian lens, it produces *functional stabilisation*: the interstate state sustains accumulation by internalising externalities just enough to preserve legitimacy. Labour gains remain reversible and profitability-bound. Supranational governance thus serves *crisis management* rather than transformation—smoothing frictions between capital fractions to avert breakdown. The *technocratic rationalisation of imperialism*: a world where exploitation grows predictable, institutionally coherent, and legally, yet no less rooted in class power.

(B) Regulation-as-restructuring: Here, supranational law reassigns control rights—workers’ co-determination, sectoral bargaining with extraterritorial reach, public options in digital and energy infrastructures, and binding just-transition compacts financed through progressive taxation. Monopoly power is treated as a *property and control* issue rather than a conduct one. By relocating decision rights, it negates the class content Miliband identifies. Rather than containing crisis, it redefines governance as an arena of *social struggle*, embedding accountability within institutional design. Its goal is not equilibrium but *emancipation*: turning global governance into a medium of collective ownership and ecological repair, rather than a manager of global capitalism.

7 Governing a World Without Outside

The synthesis lies in recognising that both trajectories—*harmonisation* and *restructuring*—express not policy alternatives but opposing logics of power within global capitalism. The *harmonisation* model stabilises the system by refining its contradictions: it preserves private ownership and seeks legitimacy through coordination, rule-making, and limited redistribution. Its premise is faith in technocratic reason—that governance can humanise accumulation without displacing it. Yet this is precisely what Miliband discredits: such regulation does not transcend class rule but perfects its administration. Supranational governance becomes *Global Capital's executive committee—Lenin's imperialism by legal means*.

By contrast, the *restructuring* model treats supranational law as a contested terrain of social struggle. It aims not to reconcile capital with social need but to reassign control

over production, data, and ecological resources. Through worker co-determination, public ownership, and transnational bargaining, it embeds antagonism within governance itself. Its measure of success is not efficiency but *politicisation*: transforming technocracy into democratic conflict over surplus, sustainability, and ownership.

Between these poles, the synthesis outlines a *conditional path*: supranational governance is historically inevitable yet normatively legitimate only if it institutionalises *countering power*. Miliband's critique warns that such counterpower cannot be delegated; it must be constitutive, woven into representation, transparency, and veto rights. In a *world without outside*, legitimacy thus hinges less on scale than on *class content*: whether governance harmonises exploitation or restructures ownership.

8 Conclusion

Marx showed that capital's universalising motion dissolves boundaries; Lenin revealed how this expansion congeals into monopoly and imperial hierarchy; Wolf demonstrated that no community remains external to this process; and Miliband exposed the state as its guardian. *Taken together*, they show that global capitalism leaves no neutral institutional space—every apparatus reflects and reproduces class power.

If supranational governance follows the logic of *harmonisation*, the outcome is clear: it consolidates the authority of multinational capital under a multilateral guise. Regulatory alignment, even in progressive idiom, entrenches the prerogatives of finance and technology giants, producing a more coherent yet equally exploitative order. The proletariat remains fragmented across jurisdictions while corporations command a unified sphere—a deepening of imperialism through bureaucracy.

If, however, the *restructuring* model prevails, the implications are transformative. It would redefine property and control at the global level: multinational boards subject to transnational labour councils, public oversight of digital infrastructures, enforceable redistribution between core and periphery. Such institutions could begin to realise Marx's vision of collective ownership in planetary form—*socialism scaled to the size of capital*.

Given the magnitude of contemporary multinationals—entities whose balance sheets exceed many national GDPs, Marx would concede that resistance demands coordination at matching scope. Yet he would insist that form follows class: supranational governance can serve emancipation only when driven by organised labour, not technocratic elites. The choice is not between national and global governance but between *capitalist* and *socialist globalisation*. In a world without outside, the liberation of labour must be as universal as its domination.

People of All Countries, Unite!

Word count: 1,614

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